

ISTQB FOUNDATION MASTERCLASS

ISTQB Interview Questions

Twenty common QA and ISTQB interview questions, grouped by theme, with what a strong answer covers.

Introduction

Employers often use ISTQB Foundation topics as the backbone of QA interviews. This resource groups twenty of the most common questions by theme and, for each, sets out what a strong answer covers. Use it to rehearse out loud rather than simply reading — being able to explain a concept clearly is what interviewers are assessing.

For each question, aim to give a concise definition, a short real-world example, and (where relevant) why it matters. Avoid reciting the syllabus word for word — interviewers value understanding over memorisation.

Theme 1 — Fundamentals of Testing

Question	What a strong answer covers
Why is testing necessary?	Reduces the risk of failures in operation; builds confidence; verifies requirements are met; testing measures quality, it does not create it.
What is the difference between an error, a defect and a failure?	Error (human mistake) leads to a defect (fault in code/document), which may cause a failure (observable wrong behaviour when executed).
Can testing prove software is defect-free?	No — "testing shows the presence, not the absence, of defects". Exhaustive testing is impossible; explain risk-based prioritisation.
What is the difference between verification and validation?	Verification: are we building the product right (meets spec)? Validation: are we building the right product (meets user needs)?

Theme 2 — The Seven Principles

Question	What a strong answer covers
Name the seven testing principles.	Testing shows presence of defects; exhaustive testing is impossible; early testing; defect clustering; the pesticide paradox; testing is context dependent; absence-of-errors fallacy.

Question	What a strong answer covers
What is the pesticide paradox and how do you handle it?	Repeating the same tests stops finding new defects; you review and revise tests, add new cases, and vary data.
What does defect clustering mean for planning?	A small number of modules usually contain most defects; focus effort there (links to risk-based testing and the Pareto principle).
Explain the absence-of-errors fallacy.	Finding and fixing many defects does not help if the system does not meet user needs — a working but wrong product still fails.

Theme 3 — Test Levels and Types

Question	What a strong answer covers
What are the four test levels?	Component (unit), integration, system, and acceptance testing — each with a different objective and test basis.
Difference between functional and non-functional testing?	Functional: what the system does (features/behaviour). Non-functional: how well it does it (performance, usability, security, reliability).
What is regression testing versus re-testing (confirmation testing)?	Re-testing confirms a specific fixed defect is resolved; regression checks unchanged areas still work after a change.
When would you use smoke testing?	A shallow, broad check that critical functions work before deeper testing — often as a build-acceptance gate.

Theme 4 — Test Techniques

Question	What a strong answer covers
What is equivalence partitioning?	Dividing input data into partitions expected to behave the same, then testing one representative value per partition to reduce test count.
Explain boundary value analysis.	Defects cluster at partition edges; test values at and just either side of boundaries (e.g. min-1, min, max, max+1).
When would you use a decision table?	When behaviour depends on combinations of conditions; it ensures each meaningful combination of inputs and outcomes is covered.
What is the difference between black-box and white-box testing?	Black-box: based on specifications, no code knowledge. White-box: based on internal structure (e.g. statement/branch coverage).
What is exploratory testing?	Simultaneous learning, test design and execution, often time-boxed with charters; strong for finding defects specs miss.

Theme 5 — Management, Tools and Behaviour

Question	What a strong answer covers
What goes into a good defect report?	Clear title, steps to reproduce, expected vs actual result, severity/priority, environment, and evidence (logs/screenshots).
Difference between severity and priority?	Severity: impact on the system. Priority: urgency of the fix. Give an example where they differ (e.g. a cosmetic bug on the homepage).
How do you decide when to stop testing?	Against exit criteria: coverage targets met, defect rates, deadlines/budget, and residual risk being acceptable to stakeholders.
How would you test a login page?	Structure the answer: valid/invalid inputs (EP/BVA), security, usability, error messages, and non-functional aspects — shows technique, not just guesses.

How to Prepare

1. Pick five questions and answer them aloud, timing yourself to around 60–90 seconds each.
2. Record or write your answers, then compare against the "what a strong answer covers" column.
3. Add one concrete example from your own experience or study projects to each answer.
4. Rehearse the definition-example-why-it-matters structure until it feels natural.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Interviewers remember candidates who give a crisp definition and then a real example. For every ISTQB concept you revise, prepare a one-sentence definition and a one-sentence example — that pairing works for almost any question.

BEST PRACTICE

Always tie your answer back to reducing risk or improving quality. Framing testing decisions around risk shows the maturity employers look for in QA hires.